CINEMA

MORE THAN A FILM FESTIVAL

The Dharamshala International Film Festival *is showcasing a lot of women filmmakers in its upcoming edition*



The 13th edition of the Dharamshala International Film Festival (DIFF) is being held from November 7-10 at McLeod Ganj in Dharamshala. As always, it will feature an adventurous and eclectic slate of independent films from India and around the world, including features, documentaries and shorts.

Over 100 filmmakers, cast and crew are expected to attend the festival. Along with post-screening interactive Q&As, there will be a range of panel discussions and masterclasses with filmmakers. There will also be a specially curated food and crafts fair.

"Every film has been carefully selected. We're thrilled to be showing Singapore director Yeo Siew Hua's much-talked about *Stranger Eyes*; Icelandic filmmaker Rúnar Rúnarsson's acclaimed *When the Light Breaks*; and Aizhana Kassymbek's Kazakh film *Madina*," says Ritu Sarin, co-founder of DIFF.

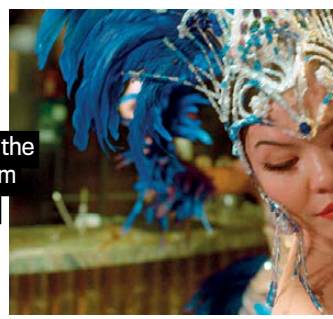
From India, there will be a wide range of films. The highlights include Payal Kapadia's Cannes Grand Prix winner, *All We Imagine as Light*; Onir's latest feature, *We are Faheem and Karun*, which will have its world premiere at DIFF; Rima Das's *Village Rockstars 2*, a sequel to her much-loved debut; and Anirban Dutta and Anupama Srinivasan's award-winning documentary, *Nocturnes*. "All these titles are made by women filmmakers and, this year, we have the most ever female-directed films in DIFF's history," adds Tenzing Sonam, co-founder of DIFF.

"At DIFF, we believe in the importance of bringing filmmakers to present their films. For audiences, there is nothing more rewarding than having a chance to meet and talk to filmmakers, given DIFF's intimate setting," says Sarin. Last year, the festival's total viewing figures from four screening spaces was around 13,000. This represents a huge growth for DIFF, which started out as a community initiative to bring good cinema to the mountains.

As part of DIFF's Community Outreach initiatives, film screenings and workshops are organised throughout the Dharamshala area, reaching out to schools, colleges, women's groups and even the Dharamshala District Jail. "The aim is to expose audiences to meaningful cinema and engage them in discussions on the subjects explored in these films," says Sonam. Further, DIFF On the Road is their initiative to take a selection of the films to various parts of the country. This is done in partnership with educational institutions, film clubs and NGOs. ■

–Neha Kirpal

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A still from the Kazakh film *Madina*

